

ICFOSS

Wide Open Windows

The International Centre for Free and Open Source Software, which is to be set up in Thiruvananthapuram, is to be a leading research organisation.

The open source movement in Kerala is all set for a giant leap. The state government has taken a bold initiative to promote research in free and open source software (FOSS). Officials claim that nowhere else across the globe has such a programme been initiated under the auspices of a state government. ICFOSS, or International Centre for Free and Open Source Software, is to be set up at Kerala's capital city Thiruvananthapuram, and is envisioned to be a leading research organisation in the free and open source model of knowledge.

"We have a clear position on the politics of knowledge control and that goes well with the position of the free software movement. In order to further the objectives laid out in our policy, we decided to create an institution that can provide leadership and vision," VS Achuthanandan, chief minister of Kerala, told LFY.

Officials say this initiative, which was approved by the state cabinet late last year, will spread the idea of 'openness' in all aspects of society. Its focus is on directing the open education initiatives based on sharing knowledge and to explore the open source concept in hardware design. ICFOSS will identify and quantify the political, cultural and economic benefits for India as a result of FOSS. Arun M, the special officer for the centre, says: "ICFOSS is going to create an action plan to make India a global leader in the open source community. We will also leverage the open source development model based on community collaboration and shared ownership of intellectual resources to bridge the digital divide. We will initiate R&D in FOSS."

Arun says the centre will create a road map for open source software development for India's software export industry and will also provide infrastructure support for FOSS-based initiatives in different parts of the state. In sectors such as e-governance, education, local information publishing and in stimulating local employment, ICFOSS will pilot FOSS-based interventions.

Consultancy and certification

According to government officials, the centre is planning to work with local, national and international institutions and networks that operate in the FOSS domain. Chief Minister Achuthanandan, who also holds the IT portfolio, says ICFOSS will ensure Kerala's leadership in the FOSS sector. Though it will start out being a small group, it will have a global vision. It will help the state government by providing intellectual inputs in

creating initiatives, and by providing leadership to various free software and free knowledge initiatives in the state. Creative work will also form a part of the ICFOSS.

Of course, developing open source software is the core mission of the centre. But it will also address issues like patents, copyright, digital content, scientific publishing and so on. ICFOSS will help the government, public enterprises, educational institutions, small businesses, individuals and some key sectors in using IT. Ajay Kumar, secretary of IT, government of Kerala, says: "The centre will create infrastructure to support FOSS-based initiatives in different parts of the state to enable people to access IT support services, and will stimulate local employment through providing support services to

FOSS-based Virtual Micro-Enterprises (VMEs), so as to enable them to start, sustain and expand operations."

The centre will also work as a consultancy to all government departments in Kerala in preparing Request-for-Proposals (RFPs), IT-related purchases, software acquisitions, certification of educational and training programs in open source, localisation of Indian languages, and to develop speech interfaces on FOSS. Open initiatives like open education, open hardware and open science initiatives will be taken care of by the centre.



Networking and research

ICFOSS will sponsor academic consultants and scholars to do research on the latest technologies in FOSS and network with leading R&D organisations in the same domain. Kumar says: "The centre will be in touch with the free software community all over the world. As a part of this mission, an International Conference on Free Software and Free Society was conducted in December 2008 in Thiruvananthapuram. Several government and non-government agencies worldwide and key players in the free software movement attended the meet. ICFOSS will build upon these relationships to make the community stronger."

The authorities are in touch with government and academic institutions from India and abroad. A delegation representing the government of Venezuela has shown interest in collaborating with the centre. On the wings of such lofty hopes, ICFOSS will start functioning by March 2009 -- but only if it doesn't get stuck in the 'politricks' the host state is notorious for. 

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